

Here is a structured breakdown of the ICD-10-CM Official Guidelines for Coding and Reporting regarding when a manifestation (or symptom/complication) is sequenced as the Principal Diagnosis (PDX) versus when the underlying condition (etiology) must be the PDX. In ICD-10-CM, the term "manifestation" can refer to a strict coding convention (e.g., "in diseases classified elsewhere") or a clinical symptom/complication. This distinction dictates the sequencing rules.

ICD-10-CM Sequencing Guidelines: Manifestation vs. Underlying Condition

Scenario / Guideline Rule	Principal Diagnosis (PDX)	Secondary Diagnosis (SDX)	Explanation & Clinical Example
Strict "Code First" Convention	Underlying Condition	Manifestation	If the ICD-10-CM tabular list dictates a "code first underlying disease" note, the etiology is always PDX. Manifestation codes (often containing "in diseases classified elsewhere") can never be the PDX. Example: Patient admitted for dementia due to Parkinson's. • PDX: Parkinson's disease (G20) • SDX: Dementia in diseases classified elsewhere (F02.80)
Symptoms Integral to the Disease	Underlying Condition	Manifestation (Not Coded or SDX)	Symptoms and signs that are an expected, integral part of the underlying disease process should not be coded as PDX when the definitive diagnosis is known. Example: Patient admitted with severe chest pain diagnosed as an acute myocardial infarction (AMI). • PDX: AMI (I21.9) • SDX: Chest pain is not coded as PDX.
Chapter-Specific Etiology Rules (e.g.,	Underlying Condition	Manifestation	Certain guidelines require the underlying

Scenario / Guideline Rule	Principal Diagnosis (PDX)	Secondary Diagnosis (SDX)	Explanation & Clinical Example
Anemia)			disease to be sequenced first even if the manifestation is the reason for the encounter. Example: Admission for management of anemia associated with a malignancy or chronic kidney disease (CKD). • PDX: Malignancy or CKD • SDX: Anemia
Non-Integral Manifestation as the Sole Focus of Care	Manifestation	Underlying Condition	If a patient is admitted primarily for a symptom/manifestation that is <i>not</i> a routine or integral part of the underlying disease, and the treatment is directed only at the manifestation. Example: Patient with gastroenteritis is admitted solely for severe dehydration requiring IV fluids. • PDX: Dehydration (E86.0) • SDX: Gastroenteritis
Dehydration due to Malignancy	Manifestation	Underlying Condition	A specific Chapter 2 guideline exception: If a patient is admitted for dehydration due to a malignancy and only the dehydration is being treated (not the cancer). Example: Patient with lung cancer admitted for IV hydration. • PDX: Dehydration (E86.0) • SDX: Lung Cancer
Treatment of Post-Operative / Care Complications	Manifestation (Complication)	Underlying Condition	When a patient is admitted for treatment of a complication

Scenario / Guideline Rule	Principal Diagnosis (PDX)	Secondary Diagnosis (SDX)	Explanation & Clinical Example
			resulting from medical or surgical care, the complication is the PDX. Example: Patient admitted for post-operative hemorrhage after a cholecystectomy. • PDX: Post-procedural hemorrhage (K91.840) • SDX: (Condition requiring surgery, if still present)
Two Interrelated Conditions (Equally Responsible)	Either Condition	The Other Condition	When a patient has a manifestation and an underlying condition that both meet the definition of PDX, and treatment is directed at both equally (and no "code first" rule applies), either can be sequenced first. Example: Patient admitted with acute respiratory failure and acute exacerbation of COPD. Treatment is directed at both. • PDX: Either Respiratory Failure or COPD • SDX: The other condition

Summary Rule of Thumb

- **Look for "Code First" Notes:** If the alphabetic index or tabular list says "*Code first underlying disease*" or if the code title includes "*in diseases classified elsewhere*," the manifestation can **never** be the principal diagnosis.
- **Focus of Treatment:** If no strict coding convention exists, ask: *What was the primary focus of the admission and treatment?* If the medical intervention was aimed exclusively at stabilizing a non-integral clinical manifestation (like dehydration or an acute hemorrhage), that manifestation typically becomes the PDX.